Modiji's resolve to make a Viksit Bharat by 2047 is more important than personal issues. All concerns are resolved. We have set a target of winning all 26 seats in Gujarat by a margin of 500,000 votes and we will achieve it.

Q. High unemployment among educated youth and inflation are some of the issues that people are talking about.
A. I do not agree that unemployment is a problem. Industries in Sanand and elsewhere invariably have boards put up to advertise vacancies. If youth want jobs, there are industries willing to give jobs. There are many opportunities to earn...I have acquired data that there are 22,000 delivery persons in Ahmedabad. Are these not jobs?

Q. But the youth are looking for stability and security in jobs. Not just gigs.
A. There are ample job opportunities for those willing to work.

Q. You have promised in your manifesto that the Summer Olympics 2036 will be hosted in Gandhinagar. But why Gandhinagar, when many Indian cities have the potential to host the Olympic Games?
A. Because hosting the Olympics requires elaborate infrastructure and much of it already exists in Ahmedabad-Gandhinagar. The Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel Sports Enclave houses the world's largest cricket stadium. Land is available around it for other infrastructure development...which complements the local economy.

Q. You have campaigned only for a day in your constituency. How will that work for you as a contestant?
A. I have grown up here, this is my home, these are my people. I have been an MLA here for 20 years. I used to paint the lotus (BJP symbol) and stick posters on the walls here. I am here only to give Modiji's message...to strengthen his hand. Our double-engine leadership and *panna* committee (party workers assigned a page each in electoral rolls to mobilise support) will ensure all voters cast their vote by 10.30 am on the polling day. ■

year and is contesting the simultaneous Vijapur assembly bypoll.

Countering the BJP's core Hindutva plank remains a challenge for Patel, who alleges displaying massive Ram temple hoardings and invoking Lord Ram's name in speeches violates the model code of conduct. The Congress candidate also dismisses Shah's perceived advantage, claiming there's a palpable anti-incumbency sentiment in the constituency. A Leuva Patidar herself, she says the demand for justice over the death of Patidar youths during the 2015-17 quota agitation still resonates in Gandhinagar, where the community constitutes 15 per cent of the electorate. Patel also alleges disquiet among women voters, stating: "When our women campaigners go door-to-door in villages, women express dissatisfaction with the government, but are too scared to voice it openly." She is confident, at least, of Kshatriya women voting against the BJP this time.

The Kshatriyas—traditionally the warrior caste—are up in arms after Union minister Parshottam Rupala's controversial remarks in March about members of princely states fraternising with the British imperialists and even marrying their daughters to them. While protests were initially confined to Saurashtra, the BJP's refusal to replace Rupala as its Rajkot candidate has stoked rumblings elsewhere too. With Kshatriyas accounting for 15 per cent of Gandhinagar's voters, state leaders concede that the row could dent Shah's winning margin, potentially costing the party half the community's votes. In Randesan village, local BJP leader Rajendrasinh Vaghela claims: "Traditionally, we voted the BJP en masse, but the Kshatriya issue has cast a shadow this time. We'll see what the community decides." Shah, however, is confident of finding a resolution before the polling day.



"THE BJP'S CONFIDENCE IS MISPLACED. IT DOES NOT ENJOY UNCONDITIONAL SUPPORT FROM ALL THE COMMUNITIES IT HAS WRONGED SO FAR"

SONAL PATEL, *AICC secretary & party's Gandhinagar candidate*

Besides a potential windfall of Kshatriya votes, Sonal Patel is also banking on the Dalit (15 per cent) and Muslim (10 per cent) support. Juhapura, one of the country's largest Muslim ghettos that was once part of the erstwhile Sarkhej assembly seat represented by Shah for 15 years, falls within this constituency. In keeping with its longstanding strategy, the BJP has made minimal Muslim outreach efforts. It has, though, fielded the Union home minister's wife and Patel's namesake, Sonal Shah, to neutralise the Congress candidate's "gender advantage" among women voters through active rural campaigning over recent weeks. With actual victory too tall an order, the question is whether the Congress can make an attempt at a moral victory at least in Gandhinagar. ■